

IN THE NEGATIVE
Anurag Kashyap in a still from *Maharaja*

HOW BUSY CAN A FILMMAKER GET? Anurag Kashyap is appearing in seven films as an actor this year. He is directing two films simultaneously. In between, he teaches at film schools across the world. Kashyap has suffered two heart attacks in the past five years and is currently making peace with asthmatic attacks and sleep apnea. Still an inspiration at 51? Most definitely.

"I keep doing," says Kashyap. "I believe in doing. I want to focus on my health, but a lot of people are dependent on me. Since I make controlled-cost films, I cannot sit at home and write something for three-four years. I must continuously do something, if not for money, then just to get out of the house and stay busy. My sickness takes over when I am at home. On set, I am energetic."

June witnessed the first burst of that energy in Tamil thriller *Maharaja* and the Hindi web series *Bad Cop*. Vijay Sethupathi-starrer *Maharaja* had Kashyap playing a burglar-rapist. The revenge drama has earned over Rs 100 crore. *Bad Cop* stars Kashyap as a gangster operating from behind bars. Kashyap is again playing baddie in the upcoming Tamil thriller *One 2 One*.

"It's got something to do with my face," laughs Kashyap, wondering why he is only cast as a villain. His tryst with acting in films began, he recalls, with A.R. Murugadoss's Hindi thriller *Akira*, where he played a corrupt cop. "*Bombay Velvet* [a 2015 crime drama directed by him] flopped," says Kashyap. "I owed a lot of money to the producers. They were making *Akira*. If I did the film, the money could be adjusted. One thing led to another." Kashyap points out that he has no ambitions of being an actor. In fact, he does not even hear scripts or know the stories. He just acts. "The way I act is also how I direct my actors," he explains. "Why should an actor know about other actors' character arcs? They only need to know what they need to do. If they get too much information, they will tailor their acting. They won't be real. Nobody is a hero or a villain. Everybody is a person with agency. Everybody is a protagonist to themselves. When you put these people together, what comes out as the story is the film."

GORAKHPUR-BORN ANURAG KASHYAP TRAINED AS AN ACTOR IN THE EARLY 1990s BECAUSE HE THOUGHT "ACTING WAS THE ONLY WAY TO GET INTO MOVIES"

Gorakhpur-born Kashyap trained as an actor in the early 1990s to enter the film industry. "Someone told me I should get a portfolio shot and approach people in the movies," he reminisces. "I didn't want to act, but I thought acting was the only way to get into movies."

Kashyap's acting journey began with his tryst with Jana Natya Manch during his days as a zoology student in Delhi. Between 1993 and 2007, he acted in plays until "the films I directed began releasing, and I stopped theatre altogether", he says. His upcoming films as an actor include Tamil productions and ace Malayalam director Aashiq Abu's *Rifle Club*. As director, one of his two projects is a film scripted by *Pataal Lok*-creator Sudip Sharma.

Despite the schedule, the once Twitter-happy Kashyap still keeps tabs on the maelstrom of Indian news, especially if it's related to cinema.

About Payal Kapadia's historic Grand Prix win for *All We Imagine as Light* at Cannes 2024, Kashyap thunders, "Indians should be ashamed that they do not support